EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

From Belief to Knowledge: Why Do People Fail to Find the Truth?

Emunot VeDeot, Introduction

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** The title and structure of the book; Rav Saadia's Introduction, the opening section (his reasons for writing) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 29 January 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

Last week was **a biographical sketch of Rav Saadia Gaon**: his life, his time period and the difficulties he went through, and **the main targets of the book**: **Christianity, Islam and the Karaites**. Tonight: a few more words of introduction for the first half, and then into the text itself.

Part 1: The Title

The book is called **ספר האמונות והדעות, Sefer HaEmunot VeHaDeot**. Rav Saadia wrote it in Arabic and called it **Kitab al-Amanat wa-l-I'tiqadat**.

Emunah and *de'ah*

"It's important to understand this always. *Emunah* is often the beginning. It's a faith. *Emunah* is something which you believe in, but you don't necessarily know it."

- "It would be wrong to say **I believe** 2 plus 2 is 4. **You know** 2 plus 2 is 4."
- Hebrew draws the same distinction, between **אמונה (*emunah*), belief**, and **ידיעה (*yedi'ah*), knowledge**.
- **I believe in *techiyat hametim***, the resurrection of the dead. Is there empirical evidence for it? No. Has anyone witnessed it? No. "So it's something you believe in. At least at this stage, it's an *emunah*."
- For many people, belief in Hashem is the same: they believe it, but they cannot rationally prove it.

The purpose of the whole book: to take our *emunot* and turn them into *de'ot*. "Things which we only believe in, which we're told to believe in, actually become things which we know are true."

Part 2: Rav Saadia and the Rambam: Two Kinds of Perplexity

About 200 years later the Rambam wrote the famous **Moreh Nevuchim, the Guide for the Perplexed**. The Rabbi read from **Alexander Altmann's introduction** to his English translation of Rav Saadia:

"There is a marked difference between the perplexity from which Maimonides sought to rescue his people and that which Saadia encountered. In the case of Maimonides the problem was summed up in the question: Aristotle or the Torah?... In the case of Saadia the situation was different. The bewilderment which characterized Saadia's own age is due not so much to the conflict between one particular creed or philosophy and the traditional faith as to the impact of so many rival creeds and philosophies upon the minds of his contemporaries."

	The Rambam	Rav Saadia
Who he is talking to	A specific person: the philosopher who knows Tanach and Aristotle and cannot square them	**The masses**
The problem	**Aristotle or Torah?**	**Too many competing faiths**
His method	Harmonise the two; sometimes he cannot, and says Aristotle is wrong	Clear away the confusion
Reach	Narrow	"Far broader and greater than that of the Rambam"

The confusion of Rav Saadia's age: Islam had begun about 300 years earlier, and many sects had arisen arguing over the correct interpretation of Muhammad. There was Eastern Christianity in Iraq at the time. And among the Jews themselves there were **Karaite Jews and rabbinic Jews**. "The simple, average Jew sees around him this kind of Muslim, that kind of Muslim, this kind of Christian," and even two kinds of Jews.

"If that was in those generations, all the more so nowadays. There are so many different people. Multiculturalism. We're faced with so many different kinds of people."

He read another line quoted in Altmann's introduction to capture the mood of the age: **Muslims, Christians, Jews and Magians** are all walking in error and darkness, and there are only two kinds of people left in the world:

One group that is intelligent but lacking in faith, and the other which has faith but is lacking in intelligence.

"How true is that today?"

Not faith against reason: faith against *pseudo*-reason

"The real conflict as Saadia sees it is not one between faith and reason, but **between faith and pseudo-reason**. Saadia insists, and his book is intended as a proof for this thesis, that intellectual speculation, if properly and patiently carried out to its final conclusion, **confirms the doctrines of the Jewish faith**. The trouble is, he asserts, that so few people care to complete their research... They pretend to follow their reason, but in fact they only follow their Nature: the irrational factors which impede the progress of true speculation, such as indolence, prejudice, resentment."

The Rabbi stressed: "This is really important. It's not a conflict between faith and reason." The debate is not *rationalists on one side, faithful Jews on the other*. It is between faith and people who claim to use their reason **but are not using it correctly**. Rav Saadia will use real reason to show that the *emunot* of the Torah "are not just *emunot*, they are *de'ot*. They are well-established principles."

Part 3: The Structure of the Book

An **introduction** and **ten essays (*ma'amarim*)**, each with its own chapters:

Essay	Subject
1	**Creation**
2	**The unity of God (*Yichud Hashem*)**
3	**Mitzvot and revelation** (Har Sinai)
4	**Free will**
5	**Good and bad** (merits and demerits)
6	**The human soul**
7	**Techiyat hametim, resurrection**
8	**Mashiach and the redemption (*Geulah*)**
9	**Reward and punishment** ("all the famous questions")
10	**Behaviour**: the golden mean, the Rambam's middle path

A warning about the Hebrew

- **Rav Saadia's Hebrew (in translation) is flowery and poetic.** "It's not like the Rambam. The Rambam always uses the most simple, clear Hebrew, which, if you understand Hebrew, is very, very easy to read." So the class will translate as it goes.
- He brings proofs from **every discipline: mathematics, astronomy, medicine, even music**.
- **He loves quoting *pesukim***: he was a linguist of biblical Hebrew, the author of the first dictionary, and the teacher of Dunash.

The Introduction

The Introduction has **eight chapters**. The first is "just an introduction to the introduction," praising Hashem. Then the purpose:

"He's going to use the ten essays to ask you to use your reason. But I need to show you that you know how to use your reason, **because people say they're using their reason but they're not using it correctly.** So that's what he's going to do in the introduction": show why people make philosophical mistakes.

Part 4: The Opening Praise

The class followed the Hebrew on **Sefaria**, with the Rabbi sharing his screen and highlighting.

The author opened and said: Blessed is Hashem, to whom the clear and certain truth **...פתח המחבר ואמר**

...is fitting

As the Rabbi translated it: Hashem **verifies for thinking beings (humans) the existence of their own souls** clearly. "Don't think God has created us and made us foolish, so we can't understand anything. No, He gives us the ability to understand things." Our senses too perceive what logic understands. Hashem has given us:

- the ability **to understand things correctly**,
- to **remove mistakes** and **remove doubts** from ourselves,
- to **use proofs** and **verify the evidence**.

"Just beginning and saying *Baruch Hashem*: He's given us the ability to think and to understand things, and that's what we're going to try to use."

Part 5: What Rav Saadia Promises

After the brief praise, Rav Saadia says he will begin **by explaining why people have doubts when they seek the truth, and how to remove those doubts**, until they reach their goal. Sometimes **false beliefs come to dominate correct ones** in people's minds, until they think the falsehood is what their own logic tells them. He will try to remove them, as David HaMelech asked:

> Open my eyes, that I may behold wonders from Your (Tehillim 119:18) **גל עיני ואביטה נפלאות מתורתך** Torah.

"Near, not far"

My wish is that this introduction, together with the whole book, should be **קרוב ולא רחוק, near and not far**.

- **From easy disciplines, not hard ones.**
- **From the roots of proofs, not their subdivisions.** "Similar to how the Ramchal began, remember? I'm going to give you the principles, not proofs from sub-things."
- So that the burden is lighter and the learning straighter, as Shlomo HaMelech said of wisdom that is near and clear: **אז תבין צדק ומשפט ומישרים כל מעגל טוב** (Mishlei 2:9), then you will understand justice and judgment and every good path.

Part 6: Why People Get It Wrong

Two reasons, even with physical things

The foundations of our judgments rest on **what we sense**: we see, smell and touch, and our minds judge on that basis. Even about **physical, sensible things**, people err for one of two reasons:

1. **Lack of knowledge.** The seeker does not have the ability or does not know how to judge.
2. **Laziness.** He has the ability, but **"he's light on himself"** and abandons careful, penetrating analysis.

Rav Saadia's example: looking for Reuven.

Reason	What it looks like
He doesn't know Reuven	Reuven may be standing next to him and he won't recognise him, or he thinks someone else is Reuven
He knows Reuven, but seeks him lazily	Half-heartedly, not wholeheartedly. "Doesn't know that to find Reuven you have to make phone calls, Google him, ask this person, ask that person," or knows all that and can't be bothered

The same two reasons in matters of the intellect

1. **He does not know how to prove things.** He thinks a proof is not a proof, and something that is not a proof is one. "He uses the wrong means to find the truth because he doesn't know what it looks like."
2. **He knows how, but is hasty:** he jumps to a conclusion **before completing his analysis**. "This is what we call in English **prejudice**. You've already made a judgment without fully thinking about it."

And when both come together, a person who is poor at analysis *and* impatient, the goal is very far, "perhaps even give up hope." **Worse still, add a third**: he does not even know what he is looking for (he does not know what Reuven looks like). Then he will reach the truth only by chance. **Worst of all**: he finds the truth but **does not realise he has it**. "People come to conclusions and they're saying the right thing, but they don't realise they're saying the right thing."

Rav Saadia's analogies: weights, deposits and coins

The creditor who cannot use scales. Someone is owed money but does not understand weights and measures. Even if his debtor pays in full, he will not know he has been paid in full. If he accepts less, he thinks he has been clever and tricked the debtor, when really he has lost out.

"Beautiful the way he uses it. Why did he give the example of weights? Because weight is a physical thing, but also **weighing up reason, weighing up arguments**. Exactly the same."

The Rabbi applied it: the advice for any big decision is to write two columns, pros and cons. But you may not know what is a pro and what is a con. And even if you list ten of each, **how much weight does each one carry?** "You end up with the wrong decision. *But I used my reason, I thought it all through, I wrote it all out!* But you used reason wrong, if you don't know the basics of how to use reason."

The banker and the currencies. A person who receives deposits and is no expert in sorting money will take the wrong currency. Or he is an expert, "but you're just lazy that day. **You didn't drink your coffee** and you're not paying attention to the money put in front of you."

Shlomo HaMelech compares wisdom and Torah to money: **כסף נבחר לשון צדיק** (Mishlei 10:20), the tongue of the righteous is **choice silver**, the correct, precise currency. Those with little skill in sorting are likened to the wicked, who muddle the truth.

Only those who take on the burden of investigation (*chakirah*) are called wise, and only then are their doubts removed.

The word recalls the Mishnah in Sanhedrin, where witnesses undergo ***chakirot***: real investigation to see if they are lying. And David HaMelech's prayer:

> **ואל תצל מפי דבר אמת עד מאד** (Tehillim 119:43) *very* true, .Do not take from my mouth a word of truth

"A beautiful expression. Not just true, but **very true**. And the only way you can get that, says Rav Saadia, is (a) you understand how to use your intellect, and (b) you are ready to put in the effort."

Part 7: Four Kinds of People

"I see," says Rav Saadia, people who have belief and knowledge in different ways. "And I told you last week: Saadia loves categorising things."

#	Who	Rav Saadia's verse
1	**Reached the truth, know it, and are happy with it**	**נמצאו דבריך ואכלם ויהי דברך לי לששון ולשמחת לבבי** (Yirmeyahu 15:16): Your words were found and I ate them; they became joy and gladness to my heart
2	**Reached the truth but doubt it**: it is not verified for them; parts seem strange or unclear	**כמו זר נחשבו** (Hoshea 8:12): it is regarded as something strange
3	**Hold a false view and are sure it is right**	**אל יאמן בשו נתעה כי שוא תהיה תמורתו** (Iyov 15:31): let him not trust in vanity, for vanity will be his return
4	**Always changing**: adopts one view, finds a problem, switches to a second, then a third, all his life	**עמל הכסילים תיגענו אשר לא ידע ללכת אל עיר** (Kohelet 10:15)

- **Category 2**, the Rabbi said, describes many believing Jews: "who know the truth but don't fully understand it, or have doubts. They haven't verified it."
- **Category 4** is like a man trying to reach a city who does not know the way. He sets off in one direction, gets lost, comes back; tries a second road, a third, a fourth. "The toil of the fool wears him out, for he does not know how to go to the city. Fantastic example. **He was never taught how to read a map.** He's got the map in front of him, and ten different paths."
- "We haven't talked about religion yet, by the way. There's nothing religious here. We can use this for your political views, whatever it may be."

A fifth category for today

"Nowadays we would add **category five**: the people who **don't bother thinking**. Saadia didn't have that. You just take whatever propaganda is put in front of you, whether advertisements or social media."

At least Rav Saadia's four categories are all thinking: even the person who reaches the wrong conclusion "is trying. He's got the wrong method, so he's come to the wrong conclusion." That, in the Rabbi's opinion, is better than not thinking at all. "And unfortunately, that is an illness which we have nowadays. People do not even bother to think."

Part 8: Why He Wrote the Book

"When I considered these categories, **my heart ached for the human species**, and my soul was stirred, at the very least, **for our people Israel**."

"I can't save humanity, but at the very least let me try to save Bnei Yisrael." In his time he saw:

- many who **profess faith**, but whose **faith is not refined** and whose **knowledge is not clear**;
- **counter-arguments growing** all around them (exactly the bewilderment of competing faiths described above);
- people **sunk in doubt and drowned in the sea of confusion**, with **no swimmer** to take their hands and lift them out of the depths.

Since Hashem has given me some knowledge with which I can support them, **I feel it is an obligation upon me**, as the prophet said: **ה' אלהים נתן לי לשון למודים** (Yeshayahu 50:4), Hashem has given me a learned tongue.

Humility

Rav Saadia confesses that **his wisdom is not complete** and his knowledge is lacking: "I'm not the wisest of my generation." He brings a verse here whose relevance the Rabbi said he could not work out. "In any case, what he's saying is: I don't know everything." Yet he does not give up hope that Hashem will help him reach his goal:

וידעתי אלהי כי אתה בחן לבב ומישרים תרצה (Divrei HaYamim I 29:17) I know, my God, that You test the heart and desire uprightness.

Part 9: The Oath: "Correct My Book"

"Let's end with a dramatic paragraph."

Rav Saadia **swears by God, the Creator of all**, that any wise person who studies this book and finds **a mistake should correct it**, or **a word that is unclear should straighten it**. And let him not say to himself, *it's not my book, I didn't write it, it's not for me to edit someone else's work*.

Why?

כי לחכמים חמלה על החכמה.For the wise have compassion for wisdom

"What a beautiful sentence." **Wise people care about wisdom.** There is a camaraderie among them, a closeness like that of relatives, as Shlomo HaMelech says: **אמר לחכמה אחתי את** (Mishlei 7:4), say to wisdom, *you are my sister*. "If there's a book out there which is wrong, we care. Edit it. Send me the mistakes." Fools, by contrast, are compassionate towards **their foolishness** and will not let go of it.

"You start to get a sense of who Saadia is. Very similar to the Rambam in the sense he's **intolerant of stupid people**. I'll be tolerant of you if you don't understand things or don't yet know the way of understanding things, and I'll try to help you. But I'm not tolerant of you if you're just foolish and lazy."

So he sends a message to all his fellow wise readers: if you see a problem in this book, tell me. "I'm not perfect, my knowledge isn't complete."

Summary

1. **The title:** *emunot* (beliefs) and *de'ot* (knowledge). **The goal: to turn belief into knowledge.**
2. **Rav Saadia and the Rambam:** the Rambam answered the philosopher torn between **Aristotle and Torah**; Rav Saadia answers **the masses bewildered by many rival faiths**, a situation very like our own multicultural world.

3. **Faith versus *pseudo*-reason:** reason, carried out properly and patiently, **confirms** the Torah. The problem is people who claim to reason but are lazy, prejudiced or resentful.
4. **Structure:** an introduction (eight chapters) and **ten essays**, from creation and God's unity to the soul, resurrection, redemption, reward and punishment and the middle path.
5. **Why people miss the truth: lack of method** or **laziness and prejudice**, and worst, not knowing what you are looking for (**Reuven**, the **scales**, the **coins**).
6. **Four kinds of people:** sure and right; right but doubting; sure and wrong; forever switching. The Rabbi's fifth: **those who don't bother to think.**
7. **Why he wrote:** "my heart ached"; people were drowning in doubt and no one was swimming out to save them.
8. **The oath:** correct my mistakes, **כי לחכמים חמלה על החכמה**.

Coming Up

Next week (back to the usual 6:30 to 7:30): finish **Chapter 2 of the Introduction** and at least Chapter 3, moving faster now that the background is done. Those who want to can read ahead in the English: "The beginning bits are quite easy. There's not much to debate."

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